revolution. These chapters talk a lot about technology, but the viewpoint is thoroughly human. The key question is, what would it mean for humans to live in the new computer-based network, perhaps as an increasingly powerless minority? How would the new network change our politics, our society, our economy and our daily lives? How would it feel to be constantly monitored, guided, inspired or sanctioned by billions of nonhuman entities? How would we have to change in order to adapt, survive and hopefully even flourish in this startling new world?

NO DETERMINISM

The most important thing to remember is that technology, in itself, is seldom deterministic. Belief in technological determinism is dangerous because it excuses people of all responsibility. Yes, since human societies are information networks, inventing new information technologies is bound to change society. When people invent printing presses or machine-learning algorithms, it will inevitably lead to a profound social and political revolution. However, humans still have a lot of control over the pace, shape and direction of this revolution – which means we also have a lot of responsibility.

At any given moment, our scientific knowledge and technical skills can lend themselves to developing any number of different technologies, but we have only finite resources at our disposal. We should make responsible choices about where to invest these resources. Should they be used to develop a new medicine for malaria, a new wind turbine or a new immersive video game? There is nothing inevitable about our choice; it reflects political, economic and cultural priorities.

In the 1970s, most computer corporations like IBM focused on developing big and costly machines, which they sold to major corporations and government agencies. It was technically feasible to develop small, cheap personal computers and sell them to private individuals, but IBM had little interest in that. It didn’t fit its business model. On the other side of the Iron Curtain, in the USSR, the Soviets were also interested in computers, but they were even less inclined than IBM to develop personal computers. In a totalitarian state – where even private ownership of typewriters was suspect – the idea of providing private individuals with control of a